

Master Lean Bulk Meal Plan — Recipes & Batch Prep System

Targets: ~2,800 kcal | ~150g protein/day **System:** Cook twice a week in bulk. Chop vegetables **fresh at cooking time**, not in advance — they go straight into whatever's cooking that session, no pre-cut storage. **Cooking sessions:** Sunday (main session) + Wednesday or Thursday (top-up session), ~60-75 min each.

PART 1 — Batch Cooking Sessions

Session 1: Sunday (cooks you through Mon-Wed)

Since you've got both a stovetop and an Instant Pot, use whichever's free — each recipe below lists both methods. Instant Pot times are listed first since they're more hands-off, but stovetop works just as well if the IP's busy or you'd rather use the stove that day:

1. Rice (~20-25 min IP / ~25 min stovetop, ~2-5 min active either way)
2. Moong dal (~25 min IP / ~30 min stovetop)
3. Soy chunk curry (~20 min IP / ~30 min stovetop)
4. Tofu stir-fry (stovetop pan, or IP Sauté mode)
5. Chilla batter (store raw, cook fresh daily — no cooking today, just mix)

If both appliances are free, run rice/dal in the Instant Pot while doing soy curry or tofu on the stove in parallel — that's the fastest path through Session 1.

Session 2: Wed or Thu (cooks you through Thu-Sun)

1. Pasta (stovetop, plain, large batch)
2. Rajma or chana masala — Instant Pot skips the overnight soak (35-40 min unattended pressure cook); stovetop needs beans soaked ahead of time
3. Paneer bhurji (stovetop pan, or IP Sauté)
4. Hummus (if making your own — otherwise store-bought, skip this step)

Everything gets divided into containers immediately after cooking and refrigerated. Rice/dal/curries keep well 4-5 days refrigerated; if you want Session 1 food to last through Wed comfortably, freeze half on Sunday and thaw as needed.

PART 2 — Master Recipes

1. Rice — Instant Pot (base carb, ~5 servings)

Ingredients: 3 cups rice, 3.5 cups water, 1 tsp salt **Method:**

1. Rinse rice until water runs mostly clear, add to Instant Pot inner pot with water and salt.
2. Pressure cook on **Manual/High, 4-5 min.**

3. Let pressure release naturally for 10 min, then quick-release remainder.
4. Fluff, cool slightly, portion into 5 containers (~¾-1 cup cooked rice each), refrigerate.

Total active time: ~2 min. Total time including pressure build-up/release: ~20-25 min, fully hands-off.

Stovetop alternative: same 3 cups rice, but 5.5 cups water. Bring to boil, cover, simmer low 15-18 min, rest covered 5 min.

2. Soy Chunk Curry — Instant Pot (~5 servings, ~150g protein total)

Ingredients: 150g dry soy chunks (nutrela-style, no pre-boiling needed), 2 onions, 2 tomatoes, 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste, 1 tbsp oil, 1 tsp turmeric, 1.5 tsp red chili powder, 1.5 tsp coriander powder, 1 tsp garam masala, salt, fresh coriander (optional) **Method:**

1. Chop onions and tomatoes fresh, right now (this is your fresh-veg moment for this dish).
2. Set Instant Pot to **Sauté**. Heat oil, sauté onions till golden (5-6 min), add ginger-garlic paste, cook 1 min.
3. Add tomatoes, cook till soft (4-5 min). Add turmeric, chili powder, coriander powder, salt — cook 1 min.
4. Cancel Sauté. Add dry soy chunks directly (no need to pre-boil) and 1.5 cups water. Stir.
5. Pressure cook on **Manual/High, 6 min**. Natural release 10 min.
6. Stir in garam masala. Cool, portion into 5 containers, refrigerate/freeze.

Skips the separate 8-10 min boil step entirely — soy chunks rehydrate and cook in the same pressure cycle.

Stovetop alternative: boil soy chunks separately in water 8-10 min until soft, drain and squeeze out excess water. Do the onion-tomato masala (steps 2-3) in a pan on the stove instead of Sauté mode, then add the boiled soy chunks + 1 cup water, simmer 10 min, finish with garam masala.

3. Moong Dal — Instant Pot (~5 servings)

Ingredients: 1.5 cups dry moong dal, 3.5 cups water, 1 tsp turmeric, salt, 1 tsp cumin seeds, 1 tsp oil/ghee, 1 chopped tomato, 2 cloves garlic (optional tadka), handful spinach **Method:**

1. Rinse dal. Set Instant Pot to **Sauté**: heat oil, add cumin seeds, garlic, chopped tomato (fresh, right now) — cook 2-3 min.
2. Cancel Sauté. Add dal, water, turmeric, salt. Stir.
3. Pressure cook on **Manual/High, 8 min**. Natural release 10 min.

4. Open, mash lightly, stir in a handful of chopped or frozen spinach — residual heat wilts it in 2-3 min.
5. Cool, portion into 5 containers.

(Swap moong for rajma/chana on your other batch session — see recipe below, same appliance, different pressure time.)

Stovetop alternative: do the tadka (step 1) in a small pan as usual. Separately, rinse dal, add to a pot with 4 cups water, turmeric, salt — boil then simmer 20-25 min until soft and mushy, mash lightly, pour tadka over, stir in spinach in the last 3-4 min.

4. Rajma / Chana Masala — Instant Pot, No Soaking Needed (~5 servings, use for Session 2)

Ingredients: 1.5 cups dry rajma or chickpeas (unsoaked — Instant Pot handles it directly), 2 onions, 2 tomatoes, 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste, 1 tbsp oil, spices same as soy curry above

Method:

1. Chop onion/tomato fresh. Set Instant Pot to **Sauté**: heat oil, sauté onions till golden, add ginger-garlic paste, then tomatoes — cook till soft (7-8 min total).
2. Add spices, cook 1 min. Cancel Sauté.
3. Add unsoaked dry rajma/chickpeas + 3.5 cups water directly into the same pot. Stir.
4. Pressure cook on **Manual/High: rajma 35 min, chickpeas 40 min**. Natural release fully (don't quick-release beans, they can spit/clog the valve).
5. Stir, mash a few beans against the pot side to thicken the masala if you like it less brothy.
6. Cool, portion into 5 containers.

Skipping the overnight soak and doing it all in one pot is the biggest time-saver here — total hands-on time is still just the ~10 min sauté step, the 35-40 min pressure cook is fully unattended.

Stovetop alternative: soak rajma/chana overnight first. Do the onion-tomato masala (step 1-2) in a pan on the stove. Boil the soaked beans separately 45+ min until soft (or use a stovetop pressure cooker for 15-20 min if you have one), then add to the masala with some cooking water, simmer 10-15 min.

5. Tofu Stir-Fry (~5 servings)

Ingredients: 2 blocks firm tofu (pressed, cubed), 1 bell pepper, 1 onion, 2-3 cloves garlic, 1 inch ginger, 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp sesame oil (or regular oil), 1 tsp chili flakes (optional), 1 tbsp cornstarch (optional, for crisping) **Method:**

1. Press tofu (wrap in towel, weight on top, 10 min) to remove water, cube it.
2. Optional: toss cubes in cornstarch for a crisper texture.

3. Heat oil in a pan, pan-fry tofu cubes until golden on a couple sides (5-6 min), remove.
4. Chop bell pepper, onion, garlic, ginger fresh right now.
5. In the same pan, stir-fry onion/pepper 3-4 min, add garlic-ginger, cook 1 min.
6. Return tofu, add soy sauce, toss 2 min. Done.
7. Cool, portion into 5 containers.

Optional: the pan-fry and stir-fry steps work fine on the Instant Pot's Sauté mode too, if you'd rather use one pot for the whole session and skip washing a separate pan.

6. Paneer Bhurji (~5 servings)

Ingredients: 400g paneer (crumbled), 2 onions, 2 tomatoes, 1 tsp turmeric, 1 tsp chili powder, 1 tsp cumin seeds, 1 tbsp oil, salt, fresh coriander **Method:**

1. Chop onions and tomatoes fresh now.
 2. Heat oil, add cumin seeds, then onions — sauté till golden.
 3. Add tomatoes, cook till soft.
 4. Add turmeric, chili powder, salt, cook 1 min.
 5. Add crumbled paneer, mix well, cook 3-4 min just to warm through (don't overcook, paneer turns rubbery).
 6. Cool, portion into 5 containers.
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7. Chilla Batter (besan or moong dal — make batter in bulk, cook fresh daily)

Ingredients (besan version): 2 cups besan (chickpea flour), water to make a pourable batter, 1 chopped onion, 1 chopped tomato, ½ tsp turmeric, ½ tsp chili powder, salt, chopped coriander **Method:**

1. Whisk besan with water to a smooth, dosa-batter-like consistency.
2. Chop onion/tomato fresh, mix into batter along with spices.
3. Store batter in fridge (keeps 3-4 days).
4. **Each morning:** heat a nonstick pan, pour a ladle of batter, spread thin, cook 2 min/side. Takes 5 min total, no separate prep needed.

(Moong dal chilla version: soak 1 cup moong dal overnight, blend with a little water + ginger + green chili into a batter instead of besan — same daily-cook method.)

8. Hummus (optional homemade, keeps 5-7 days — skip if buying store-bought)

Ingredients: 2 cups cooked/canned chickpeas, ¼ cup tahini, 2 tbsp olive oil, juice of 1 lemon, 2 cloves garlic, salt, 2-4 tbsp water **Method:**

1. Blend everything in a food processor/blender until smooth, adding water gradually to reach desired consistency.

2. Store in an airtight container, fridge, up to a week. No fresh-chopping needed here since it's all blended.
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9. Pasta (base carb for Session 2, ~5 servings)

Ingredients: 400g whole wheat pasta, salted boiling water, 1 tbsp olive oil (to prevent sticking) **Method:**

1. Boil pasta per package instructions.
 2. Drain, toss with olive oil so it doesn't clump.
 3. Portion into 5 containers, refrigerate plain.
 4. **Daily:** reheat a portion, toss fresh with olive oil/garlic, a handful of cheese, and whatever protein container you're pairing it with (tofu, paneer, soy curry). **Throw in a handful of frozen broccoli or mixed veg while reheating** — it steams through in the same 2-3 min. Keeps it from tasting like reheated mush and covers your vegetable volume for that meal.
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10. Poha (cook fresh daily, not batch-friendly — gets mushy stored)

Ingredients (single serving): 1 cup thick poha (flattened rice), $\frac{1}{4}$ onion, small handful peanuts, $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp mustard seeds, curry leaves (optional), $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp turmeric, salt, squeeze of lemon

Method:

1. Rinse poha briefly in a strainer under water, set aside to soften (2 min).
 2. Chop onion fresh. Heat oil, add mustard seeds, curry leaves, peanuts, onion — sauté 2-3 min. **Toss in a handful of frozen peas here** — they cook through in the same 2-3 min, no extra time added.
 3. Add turmeric, salt, then poha. Toss 2 min until heated through.
 4. Squeeze lemon, done. Total time: ~7 min.
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PART 3 — How Your Day Actually Assembles

Once containers exist in the fridge, here's what "cooking" looks like daily:

Meal	Effort
Breakfast (poha/chilla)	5-7 min fresh-cooked (both are quick-cook by design)
Whey shakes (x2-3/day)	30 sec, shaker + milk
Lunch/Dinner	Grab 1 carb container (rice or pasta) + 1 protein container (soy curry/dal/tofu/paneer) → microwave 2-3 min → done
Snacks	Hummus + pita, or fruit + nuts — zero cook

You're never actually "cooking" on a weekday except the 5-7 min breakfast — everything else is assembly and reheating.

PART 4 — Weekly Grocery List

For batch cooking:

- Rice (1 bag) + whole wheat pasta (1-2 boxes)
- Soy chunks (dry, ~150-200g/week)
- Dal — moong, rajma, chana (dry, rotate which one each session)
- Tofu (2 blocks) + paneer (400-500g)
- Besan (chickpea flour) or extra moong dal for chilla batter
- Onions, tomatoes, garlic, ginger, bell pepper (bought fresh each session, used same day — don't overbuy)

No-cook staples (always stocked):

- Milk (for shakes — buy every 3-4 days so it stays fresh)
- Curd/Greek yogurt
- Hummus (store-bought, or your own batch)
- Bread/pita, Kirkland Mexican shredded cheese, avocados
- Nuts, peanut butter, bananas, apples
- Poha (flattened rice) — quick daily-cook staple, buy in bulk, doesn't spoil

Spices/pantry (restock monthly, not weekly):

- Turmeric, chili powder, coriander powder, garam masala, cumin seeds, mustard seeds, salt, oil

PART 5 — Daily Timing (recap, unchanged from before)

Time	What
7:30 AM	Wake, water, banana/coffee
7:45 AM	Bus to gym
8:10-9:40 AM	Train
9:55 AM	Bus home
10:20 AM	Breakfast — shake + poha/chilla (fresh-cooked, 5-7 min)
Midday	Lunch — reheated carb + protein container, 2-3 min
Afternoon	Snack — hummus/pita or fruit+nuts, zero cook
Evening	Dinner — reheated carb + protein container
11:15-11:30 PM	Milk + nuts before bed

Class-day specifics (Mon/Wed 6:30 PM fixed, second class TBD) slide meal *times* around this structure exactly as worked out earlier — the food itself doesn't change, just when you eat it.

PART 6 — What to Eat, When (Full Week, Both Scenarios)

Food rotates through your batch-cooked containers so nothing repeats two meals in a row. Times match the schedule from Part 5. Once you know whether you land the MW 3:30 class or the TR 12:30 class, just use that scenario's column and ignore the other.

Container rotation logic: Sunday's cook session (rice, soy curry, moong dal, tofu stir-fry, chilla batter) carries you Mon-Wed. Thursday's cook session (pasta, rajma/chana, paneer bhurji) carries you Thu-Sat. Sunday itself is your next cook day, so it gets a lighter/flexible menu.

SCENARIO A — if you get MW 3:30-4:50 (Mon/Wed = two classes)

Day	7:30 AM	10:20 AM	Midday	Afternoon	Evening	11:15 PM
Mon	Wake, banana/coffee, train 8:10-9:40	Shake + poha	1:00 PM — rice + soy curry (biggest meal)	5:00 PM — shake or hummus+pita (before 6:30 class)	8:20 PM — rice + tofu stir-fry	Milk + nuts
Tue	Same routine	Shake + chilla	2:00 PM — rice + moong dal	6:00 PM — fruit + nuts	8:30 PM — rice + soy curry	Milk + nuts
Wed	Same routine	Shake + poha	1:00 PM — rice + tofu stir-fry	5:00 PM — shake or hummus+pita	8:20 PM — rice + moong dal (last of Session 1)	Milk + nuts
Thu	Same routine (Session 2 cook day — cook after breakfast or in the evening, your call)	Shake + chilla	2:00 PM — pasta + paneer bhurji	6:00 PM — hummus + pita	8:30 PM — pasta + rajma/chana	Milk + nuts
Fri	Same routine	Shake + poha	2:00 PM — pasta + rajma/chana	6:00 PM — fruit + nuts	8:30 PM — pasta + paneer bhurji	Milk + nuts
Sat	Same routine	Shake + chilla	2:00 PM — pasta + paneer bhurji	6:00 PM — hummus + pita	8:30 PM — pasta + rajma/chana	Milk + nuts
Sun	Same routine (Session 1 cook day)	Shake + oats or leftover chilla	2:00 PM — leftover pasta/rajma or whatever's left	6:00 PM — hummus + pita	8:30 PM — freshly cooked rice + soy curry (first of new batch)	Milk + nuts

SCENARIO B — if you get TR 12:30-1:50 (Mon/Wed one class, Tue/Thu one class)

Day	7:30 AM	10:20 AM	Midday	Afternoon	Evening	11:15 PM
Mon	Wake, banana/coffee, train 8:10-9:40	Shake + poha	12:30 PM — rice + soy curry	6:00 PM — shake (light, before 6:30 class)	8:20 PM — rice + tofu stir-fry	Milk + nuts
Tue	Same routine	Shake + chilla	11:15 AM — rice + moong dal (before 12:30 class, quick)	2:15 PM — hummus + pita (right after class)	7:30 PM — rice + soy curry	Milk + nuts
Wed	Same routine	Shake + poha	1:30 PM — rice + tofu stir-fry	6:00 PM — shake (light, before class)	8:20 PM — rice + moong dal	Milk + nuts
Thu	Same routine (Session 2 cook day)	Shake + chilla	11:15 AM — leftover Session 1 item + rice (before 12:30 class)	2:15 PM — hummus + pita	7:30 PM — pasta + paneer bhurji	Milk + nuts
Fri	Same routine	Shake + poha	2:00 PM — pasta + rajma/chana	6:00 PM — fruit + nuts	8:30 PM — pasta + paneer bhurji	Milk + nuts
Sat	Same routine	Shake + chilla	2:00 PM — pasta + paneer bhurji	6:00 PM — hummus + pita	8:30 PM — pasta + rajma/chana	Milk + nuts
Sun	Same routine (Session 1 cook day)	Shake + oats	2:00 PM — leftovers, whatever's left	6:00 PM — hummus + pita	8:30 PM — freshly cooked rice + soy curry	Milk + nuts

Reading either table: every row = one full day. Carb source (rice/pasta) and protein source (soy curry/dal/tofu/paneer/rajma) just rotate through whatever's sitting in the fridge from the last cook session — you don't need to think about it, just alternate so lunch and dinner aren't identical.

PART 7 — Vegetables, Fruit, Fats & Micronutrients (Daily Add-Ons)

The recipes above use onion/tomato/pepper as flavor bases, not as real vegetable volume — at 2,800 kcal you need more actual vegetable mass than that provides. Fix it with additions that require zero extra prep:

Vegetables — aim for 400-600g/day total

- Keep a bag of **frozen mixed vegetables** and **frozen broccoli/spinach** on hand — dump a handful straight into whatever's reheating (rice bowl, pasta, curry) with no chopping, no spoilage risk. This solves the "veggies don't survive the fridge" problem you raised earlier, since frozen ones don't need to.
- Add a side salad (cucumber, carrot, whatever's fresh that day) at one meal — 5 min, no cooking.

Fruit — 2-3 servings/day

- Rotate banana, apple, orange, grapes, and frozen berries (blend into shakes) instead of just banana every day.

Healthy fats — 1 daily add-on beyond what's already in the plan

- 1 tbsp ground flaxseed or chia seeds stirred into a shake, or a small handful of walnuts — cheap insurance on top of the peanut butter/nuts/avocado/ghee already in the plan.

Micronutrients worth supplementing (vegetarians commonly fall short here):

- **B12** — 500-1000 mcg, few times/week
- **Vitamin D3** — 1000-2000 IU/day, with a meal containing fat
- **Omega-3** — algae-based, if you want it (fish is the usual source and you're vegetarian)
- Consider a bloodwork check once a semester if you want actual numbers instead of guessing

PART 8 — Weekly Protein Rotation (avoid 5-months-of-sameness)

Rather than the exact same 5 proteins every single week, rotate the batch-cooking lineup across a 3-week cycle so things stay interesting over a full semester:

	Session 1 (Sun)	Session 2 (Thu)
Week A	Soy curry, moong dal, tofu stir-fry	Paneer bhurji, rajma
Week B	Tofu stir-fry, chana masala, soy curry	Paneer bhurji, moong dal
Week C	Soy curry, rajma, tofu stir-fry	Chana masala, paneer bhurji

Same recipes, same effort, just swap which 2-3 you make that week. Repeat the 3-week cycle through December.

PART 9 — Emergency Meal (for the days you truly can't reheat anything)

Exam weeks happen. Keep one of these always stocked as a zero-effort fallback so a chaotic day doesn't become a missed-calorie day:

- Greek yogurt + granola + a banana
 - Peanut butter sandwich + a glass of milk
 - Hummus wrap (pita, hummus, cheese, whatever raw veg is around)
 - A double whey shake (milk + 2 scoops) as a full meal replacement — not ideal daily, but fine as a true fallback
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PART 10 — Protein Distribution Per Meal

Hitting 150g/day matters less if it's lopsided (e.g. 20g at breakfast, 60g at dinner). Muscle protein synthesis responds better to protein spread across the day. Rough per-meal targets with this plan's foods:

Meal	Target	How it hits
Breakfast	30-40g	Shake (32g) + chilla (~15g) already gets you here; poha days are lower (~20g) — add a second half-scoop shake if you went poha that morning
Lunch	30-40g	Rice/pasta + soy curry, tofu, paneer, or dal container
Snack	15-20g	Hummus+pita (~14g) or Greek yogurt instead of plain curd on snack days
Dinner	30-40g	Same structure as lunch, different protein container
Before bed	10-15g	Milk + nuts

No new cooking needed — just be aware that poha mornings run protein-light and either lean on the shake harder or swap in Greek yogurt that day.

PART 11 — Pre-Workout Carb (Optional Add-On)

Banana + coffee at 6 AM is a fine baseline for a fasted-ish lift. If you notice low energy mid-session (common once volume ramps up in Phase 2/3), add one of these before training instead of just banana:

- 2 slices toast + jam
- A granola bar
- A second banana

Not mandatory daily — just have it ready for sessions where you're dragging.

PART 12 — Weight Tracking Protocol

The 2,800 kcal target is a calculated starting point, not a guarantee — validate it against real data over the first 2-3 weeks:

- Weigh every morning, after the bathroom, before eating, same conditions
 - Track the **weekly average**, not single-day numbers (daily weight swings 1-2kg from water/food volume alone)
 - Target: **0.25-0.5% of bodyweight gained per week** (~150-300g/week at your current weight)
 - Gaining slower than that for 2+ weeks → add 150-200 kcal/day
 - Gaining faster than that → cut 150-200 kcal/day
 - Recalculate protein target (stays ~2-2.5g/kg) as bodyweight climbs
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PART 13 — Container Labeling & Hydration

Labeling: when you portion each batch-cooked item, label the container with date cooked + recipe name (a strip of tape + marker is enough). Makes rotation decisions instant instead of guessing what's what or how old it is in the fridge.

Hydration: aim for 2.5-3.5 liters/day, more on training days or if it's hot. Easy to lose track of when you're focused on macros — worth keeping a water bottle with you between classes as a physical reminder.

Bottom Line

- **2 cooking sessions/week**, ~60-75 min each, produces ~5 days of protein + carb containers
- **Vegetables always chopped fresh at cooking time**, never pre-cut and stored — frozen veg added to reheats covers the daily volume gap with zero prep
- **Poha and chilla are your only daily-fresh items**, both under 7 minutes
- **Rotate the protein lineup every 3 weeks** so 5 months of eating doesn't feel repetitive
- **Spread protein across meals** (~30-40g each) rather than backloading it
- Keep one **emergency no-cook meal** always stocked for exam weeks
- **Track weekly-average weight for 2-3 weeks** and adjust calories based on actual results, not just the calculated starting point

- Everything else is reheat-and-eat